

Episode 37: New Year Special – Pre-Broadcast Special! *Hakaba Kitaro* Starts This Week!

A new year has arrived. How did everyone spend New Year's?

This year, our household was in mourning, so it didn't really feel much like "New Year's." I worked until the 30th, went to Asakusa on New Year's Eve to eat year-end soba, then came home to drink wine and crash while watching the Red and White Song Battle. After the new year began, I didn't even do the "traditional New Year's Eve night card writing" (← So late!). On the 1st and 2nd, I just paid visits to my parents' house and my wife's parents' house respectively, and that was it. I spent just the 3rd relaxing for the day, then started regular work from the 4th. That's about it.

Thanks to that, I had no "New Year's stupor" and was able to jump into full-throttle work mode, which feels good. And at the start of work, I received various souvenirs from people who had gone home for the holidays. Since both my wife and I were born in Tokyo, we don't have the experience of what's called "going home" during New Year's and such. So while listening to stories about New Year's at their hometowns from people who went home, I munched on the sweets they brought back. I received all sorts of things again this year (laugh).

One item that's become a regular souvenir every year is "Mamadohru." Oh my, it's incredibly delicious! It's a souvenir from Sakuma-san, who shares my office—a Fukushima speciality. Ah, the blissful "Mamadohru" (joy). Please bring some again next time (laugh).

That's my new year.

However...

Something around my belly seems to have increased considerably... Huh? That's strange... even though we were in mourning (← meaningless).

Well then.

New Year calls for "specials," of course. So this week is brought to you as a special (laugh).

I've been involved in several projects since last year, including *Hataraki Kids: My Ham-gumi* and *Saint Seiya: Hades Elysion Chapter* (聖闘士星矢 冥王ハーデス エリシオン編), but the main focus right now is definitely *Hakaba Kitaro* (墓場鬼太郎).

I didn't know this, but apparently this January marks the 40th anniversary of the TV version of *Kitaro*. Forty years ago means 1968 (Showa 43). I was still only 5 years old then (laugh). The first episode apparently aired on January 3rd of that year. January 3rd, no less! These days, it would be almost impossible to have a new anime series start on a nationwide network on January 3rd, right? It must have been a production they really put their heart into.

That first *GeGeGe no Kitaro* was a black-and-white anime. According to Toei Animation's website, it was "Toei Doga's final black-and-white production." Ah, that's right. I think our house already had a colour TV by then, so it was a work from exactly that transition period.

In our house at the time, I wasn't really allowed to watch TV anime much, and I probably didn't know about *GeGeGe no Kitaro*. Well, I do have some vague memory of glimpsing it back then. But I wasn't watching it every week without fail or anything like that. The so-called second series of *Kitaro* that was made several years later—I remember watching that quite a bit.

I properly watched that black-and-white *Kitaro* when I was in middle school or high school, I think it was summer? Around that time, Fuji TV was rerunning it from about 6

AM on Sunday mornings. I think they might have been broadcasting it without commercials? I watched it every week without fail. In a room with the shutters still closed, staying dark, watching the black-and-white *Kitaro*. It had a really good atmosphere and was somehow scary.

"Jigoku Nagashi" (Hell Current), "Yasha," "Suiko" (Water Tiger), "Oritatami Nyudo" (Folding Monk), "Vampire Elite"—these were episodes I loved. I still remember them pretty well when I think back. "Daikaijuu" (Great Sea Monster) and "Obake Naita" (Ghost Night Game) were especially good. After watching "Obake Naita," I remember unconsciously groaning "Uuu~mu! (grin)" (laugh).

So, 40 years after that black-and-white *Kitaro*, *Hakaba Kitaro* begins this Thursday, January 10th.

Actually, in preparing for this production, I read the restored original manga for the first time. It had such a nostalgic scent, yet was very innovative, very rich but also refreshing. It was an original work overflowing with indescribable charm. Man, I was hooked! I wish I could have encountered and read it much earlier. Additionally, as visual reference material, we had them gather art books of Mizuki-sensei's work, and I got completely absorbed in those too. Amazing, the worldview and colour sensibility of Mizuki Shigeru.

How to bring this unique atmosphere to the screen—director Chioka and all the staff worked on this together, feeling our way, and somehow managed to give it shape.

I'll write just a little about it (laugh), but usually screens are almost entirely determined by the combination of animation/finishing and backgrounds. This time, however, special screen processing in photography is added to that. This photographic processing creates the unique atmosphere in the final result.

However, that photographic processing dramatically changes how both the cels and backgrounds look. We create the cel colours using "reverse calculation" thinking: "To make the screen look like this in the final result, what colours should the cels be?"

So the colours of cels painted according to the colour direction are very different from the cel colours in the actual completed screen. For this production, we created a colour conversion filter specifically for colour direction. When creating character colours, we place this filter over the cels to check the colour tones. Honestly, it's incredibly time-consuming, but working while getting excited about how the screen will turn out is very enjoyable.

After a difficult production process, episode #1 was completed right at the end of last year. The night before delivery, late at night, I watched the completed version of #1 in the editing room at Oizumi Studio, and man, Nozawa Masako-san's voice as Kitaro gave me chills (laugh). Yeah, it's perfect—actually beyond my imagination, and I was moved. It's been a while since I was this happy hearing a voice performance. Somehow, it felt like something connected deep in my memory.

In that way, not just the story and direction, but also in terms of animation and screen texture, plus voice and music, I think it's turned out to be a production with considerable spirit put into it. Some unexpected people are involved in the OP and ED, but I'm apparently not supposed to reveal that yet, so it's a secret (laugh). Ah, there are many other things I'd like to write about, but first, please watch *Hakaba Kitaro*.

Unfortunately, it's basically broadcasting in the Kanto local slot, and the networked Kansai and Tokai regions will have broadcasts about a week delayed. Ah, I wish people nationwide could watch it. People in other regions will probably have to wait for the DVD?

In any case, please look forward to it!

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